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STRESS AND THE *WAW* "CONSECUTIVE" IN BIBLICAL HEBREW

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The stress patterns of biblical Hebrew are most easily explained as derived from a stage in which words ending in a consonant had final stress, words ending in a vowel, penultimate. Consequently, stress position in the great majority of verb forms with *waw* consecutive—perfect and imperfect—must have been the same, at this stage, as in the corresponding forms in other uses, and in most cases the forms would have been identical. Suggestions are made as to how the marks now distinguishing *waw* consecutive forms arose, and as to the historical context in which such marks became necessary.

1. THE NATURE AND ORIGIN OF *waw* CONSECUTIVE FORMS IN HEBREW are a perennial problem. Attempts to find a solution always involve stress patterns, but these are invariably regarded as the result of a historical process, not as part of an existing system.¹ Consequently a part of the information which they convey is ignored.

2. The stress patterns of biblical Hebrew can be described as follows:

2.1 A word ending in a consonant has final stress, as *dab'or*, *dab'ar*, *dabar'im*, *qat'al*, *qatalim*, *yiq'tol*, *wayyiq'tol'un*.

EXCEPT (i) Segolate form nouns and corresponding structures, as *k'elep*, *s'eper*, *maml'eket*, *h'erep*, *wat'iben*, *bən'ayik*.

(ii) Some *waw* consecutive imperfect forms with open penultimate syllable (as described in #10.1), also *hišš'omer* (see note 19), in contextual position.²

(iii) 3fs perfect verb forms with 2fs or 3mpl suffix, as *ganab'otam* (Gen 31:32), *šobab'etek* (Is 47:10).³

2.2 A word ending in a vowel has final stress if it derives from a root III ², or (except for the forms mentioned in #2.3) III *h*, as *gāl'a*, *yigl'e*, *wayyes'e*, *gāl'u*, *ro'e*, *bor'e*, *naq'i*, or where the final vowel represents a suffixed pronoun, the fs nominal ending, or the "gentilic" ending, or a similar ending in a few other nouns, as *dabar'o*, *dabar'i*, *šon'a*, *azzot'i*, *naptol'i*.

2.3 A word ending in a vowel also has final stress in (other) forms ending in -CəCV. These occur in contextual position only. Examples are verb forms ending in a vowel representing a pronominal element, as *qatāl'u*, *tiqtāl'i*, *yiq'tāl'u*, and some words from root III *h*: nouns of the form *pār'i*, *hāl'i*, and the corresponding verb forms as *yāh'i*, *yāh'i*, also some pronominal morphs, as *ān'i*, *hinnān'i*, *dabarək'a*.

EXCEPT forms in which -*ah* "directional" is bound to a noun originally ending -CVCC, as *ohēl* also *l'ayāl*.

¹ This is true even of the description of syllable structure and stress patterns in J. Blau, "Hebrew Stress Shifts, Pretonic Lengthening, and Segolization: Possible Cases of Aramaic Interference in Hebrew Syllable Structure" in *Israel Oriental Studies* 8 (1978), 91–106 (henceforward "Blau"). This description is "mainly synchronic" (p. 92). The reason for the omission of construct forms (as having weak or no stress) is no doubt valid historically, but is not true of the primary evidence. Stress is marked here by a vertical stroke (') before the stressed vowel. The Hebrew vowels are represented as *u* (*shureq*, *qibbus*), *o* (*holem*), *ɔ* (*qameš*), *a* (*patah*), *ε* (*segol*), *e* (*šere*), *i* (*hireq*), *ə* (*shewa*), *š*, *ā*, *ē*, (composite *shewa*). A circumflex denotes the presence of a vowel letter, *w* for *ū*, *ô*, *y* for *î*. Other non-consonantal uses of *w*, *y*, and *h* are ignored.

² In the cases described in #3, a word appears in a special pausal form at the end of a syntactic/semantic unit (pausal position). Within these units (contextual position) the contextual form is used. For the distribution of pausal forms, see *JSS* 25 (1980), 165–179, *VT* 31 (1981), 186–199, and note 5 below.

³ Both words are in pausal position. For similar forms in contextual position, see Jos 2:6, Is 47:14, Hos 2:14, Ps 48:7 and Rut 4:15.

2.4 A word ending in a vowel has penultimate stress in all other cases: i.e., all words ending in -CVCV or -CVC:V, or -CVCCV which do not come under #2.2 above.

EXCEPT the following forms in contextual position:

- (i) Some 1cs and 2ms perfect forms with *waw* consecutive (described in #7),
- (ii) The pronouns ⁷*att'w*, ⁷*ʔonok'i*, the adverb ⁷*att'w*,
- (iii) Occasional verb forms ending -CVCV or -CVC:V, as ⁷*ur'i*, ⁷*hōš'i*⁷, ⁷*qall'ū*.⁴
- (iv) M pl. construct forms, and some particles, such as *hinn'e*, which do not appear in pausal position.

3. Suprasegmental contours induce change at the end of syntactic/semantic units⁵ as follows:

Pausal forms. An original short vowel in the stress syllable is represented by its long reflex⁶ if this is not true of the contextual form.

3.1 If the word ends in a consonant, there is no change in stress position, as *bən'ay/bən'ay*, *šəm'ar/šəm'ar*, *k'ešep/k'ešep*, *ʔal/ʔal*, also *hitqaʔt'el/hitqaʔt'el*, *dibb'er/dibb'er*.

EXCEPT in the *waw* consecutive imperfect forms listed in #2.1.ii above, where penultimate stress becomes final, as *wayy'wqəm/wayy'wq'om*, *wayy'ešeb/wayy'eš'eb*.

3.2 If the word ends in a vowel, final stress becomes penultimate, except in the forms listed in #2.2. Thus: *qat'el'ū/qat'el'ū*, *yiq'tol'ū/yiq'tol'ū*, *pər'i/p'eri*, *yəh'i/y'ehi*, *ʔan'i/ʔ'ni*, *hinnən'i/hinn'en'i*, *dəbərək'w/dəbər'ekw*. But it should be noted that, in the forms in #2.4.i and #2.4.ii, the stressed vowel is not always represented by

its long reflex, a phenomenon sometimes referred to as "minor pause," as ⁷*att'w/ʔattw* or ⁷*ʔattw*, *wəšwma'w/*
wəšwma'w or *wəšwma'w*.

3.3 *Qameš on conjunctive waw.* The conjunction is pointed in this way when it is prefixed to

(i) a word stressed on its first syllable, which is second of a pair of words functioning as a unit. Nouns of original forms *CaC: and *CVCy appear in pausal form in this situation;⁷ words of type #2.4.i and #2.4.ii appear in "minor pause" as ⁷*an'i wə'attw* in 2 Kgs 9:25, and this is true of a *waw* consecutive perfect form standing as the second word in such a phrase in ⁷*ʔb'ō wənilh'amit*, 1 Sam 29:8,

(ii) a noun with adverbial ending used as the last word in a phrase of the type "from X and onwards" as *mibb'en šišš'im šən'w wəm'a'w* (Lev 27:7),

(iii) a verb (or a negative) acting as an independent clause, as *umw'w ʔet-re'ehu wəm'et* (Dt 19:5), *məbaqəš'im m'ayim wə'ayin* (Is 41:17),

(iv) (occasionally) a verb with following subject or modifiers,⁸ *wəm'etū kəl-hašš'o'n* (Gen 33:13).

3.4 *Nesiga (Retraction of the Stress)*—This phenomenon occurs at the end of phrases or larger units.⁹

⁷ See HAR 5 (1981), 76–84 for the general use of *qameš* on conjunctive *waw*, and for the pausal forms of these nouns, p. 87, 91.

⁸ Situations (ii), (iii), and (iv) are described in HAR 5 (1981), 77–78, 80. Ez 47:9 should be added to the list in note 12 there. As noted in that article (p. 82–3) the accentuation of MT does not always reflect the situation which gave rise to *qameš* on conjunctive *waw* (or the other pausal phenomena). However it generally does so. In the typical case where the conjunction pointed with *qameš* joins two words functioning as a unit (#3.3.i), the word before the conjunction has a conjunctive accent in 348 of 434 cases (80%). In situation #3.3.ii this word has a disjunctive in 54 of 66 cases (82%), and in situation #3.3.iii it has a disjunctive in 54 of 56 cases (96%). These cases show that *qameš* really is induced by the pausal situation at the end of a clause, and not simply by the close connection with the preceding word. In situations #3.3.i and #3.3.iv, this pausal vovelling is induced at the end of a constituent of a clause, as is the pausal vovelling of some nouns (see note 7), and as is *nesiga*.

⁹ On *nesiga* see *Estudios Masoréticos*, ed. E. Fernández Tejero, Madrid, 1983, 37–48, derived from a comprehensive study. The best earlier study is that of F. Praetorius, *Über den rückweichenden Accent im Hebräischen*, Halle a.S., 1897.

⁴ Jud 5:12, Ps 118:25, Jer 4:13. For the distribution of these forms, see G. Bergsträsser, *Hebräische Grammatik*, vol. II, Leipzig, 1929, #28c.

⁵ *Qameš* on conjunctive *waw*, *nesiga*, and the pausal forms of nouns, occur at the ends of phrases. Other pausal forms occur at the ends of larger units, most commonly clauses.

⁶ The original short vowels, *a*, *i*, *u*, are represented in the Masoretic Text (MT) by a "long reflex" (*ṣ*, *e*—also *a*, and *o*) under main stress and in some other open syllables, and by a short reflex (*a*, *e*, *i*, *u*, *ṣ*, and *ə*) elsewhere. Under the definition given here and in note 1, construct nouns are contextual forms, and absolute nouns are pausal forms, but, since the two groups are traditionally kept separate, the construct/absolute variation is not included with the contextual/pausal variation here. However the long reflex forms of nouns of original form *CaC: and *CVCy are treated as pausal forms here.

Where a word ending -CVCV, -CVC₂CV, or (where the final vowel was originally short)¹⁰ -CVCVC, is followed by a word stressed on its first syllable, to which it is joined by a conjunctive accent, stress is retracted to the penultimate vowel, regularly if the two words are a construct pair, or a verb or infinitive and its subject or modifier, sporadically elsewhere.

Under the same conditions, 1cs and 2ms *waw* consecutive perfect forms show penultimate stress, as *wəyɔʃ'abtɔ b'ɔh* Dt 17:14. This is the only situation in which stress is retracted to a closed penultimate syllable.¹¹

4. This survey shows that, in general, words ending in a consonant have final stress, words ending in a vowel have penultimate stress. The major exceptions to the patterns are exceptions for clear historical reasons. The major group of words ending in a consonant which show penultimate stress is #2.1.i those of "sego-late" structure, in which the final vowel was introduced to break up a final consonant cluster. The major group of words ending in a vowel which show final stress is #2.2, in which the stressed final vowel was originally followed by a consonant, or reflects in some way an earlier -VC(V). In these two groups of exceptions, which clearly result from morphophonemic change which did not affect stress position, there is no change in the stress position under the influence of suprasegmental contours. In most other cases in which the contextual form is not stressed according to the general pattern, the pausal form is so stressed. The only exceptions are forms like *b'ɔyətɔ* (if this can be considered an exception) where the stress position remains unchanged for obvious historical reasons, and 3fs perfect forms with suffixes of form -VC, in which the stress position is anomalous, for no known reason, both in contextual and in pausal position.

5. These morphological considerations show that, where the same stress pattern is shown in both pausal

and contextual position, it reflects a rather early stage of the language,¹² since considerable change has occurred in some forms since the pattern was fixed. Where the stress position differs in pausal and contextual situations, it is clear in some cases that the pausal form reflects an early stage of the language, from which the contextual form is a later development. Thus **piryun*—**piry* gives rise to *p'ərɪ* in pause (stressing the original vowel), but *pər'i* in context (with the original vowel reduced). Similarly **qatalū* gave rise to *qət'ɔlū* in pause, when the penultimate vowel was still present, whereas it is reduced in the contextual form to *qətəl'ū*.¹³ Where the two forms are stressed differently, there is in no case any similar indication that the contextual form represents a stage of the language earlier than does the pausal, whether the form ends in a consonant or in a vowel.

6. This survey shows that where the stressing of the *waw* consecutive form differs from that of other uses of the perfect or imperfect form, the stressing of the *waw* consecutive form stands out as an exception to the standard pattern. There are a few other cases of exceptions which cannot be defined in terms of phonology, but must be defined on a morphological or semantic basis, but the *waw* consecutive forms distinguished by stress position form by far the largest group of these, both in the case of perfect (#2.4.i) and of imperfect forms (#2.1.ii). This suggests that further investigation of these forms is desirable.

7. THE *waw* CONSECUTIVE PERFECT.

The *waw* consecutive perfect is distinguished from other uses of the perfect only in 1cs and 2ms forms.

¹² The 3fs perfect forms with suffix (#2.1.iii) may be an exception. It can be noted that words ending with labial or voiceless consonants (as these do) sometimes appear to show a tendency to act as words ending in open syllables (see note 27).

¹³ And so *hər'ɔgū* (Ez 23:10) in pause, but when the original penultimate vowel had been reduced, stress is retracted through *nesiga* to the preceding syllable, as *h'ɔrəgū* ¹⁴ (Gen 49:6). It is probable that this reduction occurred between the time of the Qumran texts, in which *waw* is frequently used as a vowel letter where MT has *shewa* in *yiqtalū* forms (see E. Qimron, *A Grammar of the Hebrew Language of the Dead Sea Scrolls*, Jerusalem 1976, #311.131, p. 160) and the time of Origen's transliterations, in which a vowel is not usually written where MT has *shewa* in a verb form of this sort unless a guttural is involved (see E. Brønno, *Studien*

¹⁰ The vowel is usually *a*, *e*, or *e*, occasionally other, as *t'ɔʃb* 1 Kgs 17:21, *wəy'ɔqəm* Job 22:28. The vowel was apparently long in *t'ɔʃt* Job 14:13 (see I. Yeivin, *The Aleppo Codex of the Bible*, Jerusalem, 1968, p. 293, #4). Cf. the retraction in *hif'el* imperfect forms in Hos 14:10, Ps 18:12, Prov 1:5, 9:9, 20:22, at least some of which are indicative.

¹¹ The only other possible cases are imperfect forms from *hyh*, as *wayy'ihyū* Jos 4:9. It is likely, however, that the *he* had no consonantal value, or possibly it was followed by vocal *shewa* as suggested by Praetorius, op. cit. p. 33.

These forms show final stress, contrasting with the penultimate stressing of perfect forms in other uses. However this distinction is only made regularly in forms from strong, hollow, or geminate roots, as *wəʔəkalt'ə*, *wahāqimot'i*. In forms from roots III *h*, final stressing occurs only where the antepenultimate syllable was closed, or open with a long vowel: i.e. in stems other than *qal*, as *wəkillit'ə*, *wəzerit'i*, and in forms from roots III *ʔ* final stressing also occurs, as a rule, in derived stems, not in the *qal*. Even in derived stems, however, penultimate stress is quite common.¹⁴ Thus only a small proportion of *waw* consecutive perfect forms are distinguished by stress position. Moreover this distinction is obliterated in situations in which suprasegmental contours affect vowel or stress patterns (see #3.2–4). *Nesiga* is of particular interest here, since it is only in *waw* consecutive perfect forms that the stress is retracted to a closed syllable (see #3.4 and note 11).

8. The information given above on words ending in a vowel shows that (with the exception of group #2.2, where the standard pattern is obscured through morphophonemic change) stress is final only in contextual position, and only in some words. This final stress definitely represents a development later than the penultimate pausal stressing in some cases, and probably does so in all. If this is the case, then, the stress patterning can be described as follows: Suprasegmental contours induce final stress in contextual position in verb forms ending -CVCV in which the penultimate vowel was originally short, in verb and noun forms arising from *CVCy or *CVCw in which the vowel was short, and in some pronominal morphs under the same conditions. Where the penultimate vowel was long, or the penultimate syllable closed, final stress in contextual position occurs only sporadically. Consequently the consistent final stressing of 1cs and 2ms *waw* consecutive perfects, ending -VCCV (or -VC:V), is anomalous, and must represent a special development within the language. It seems highly probable that the possibility of final stress in these forms has been used to provide a means of marking a

semantic category which was otherwise not distinguished. The use of this marker was evidently blocked in 1cpl forms—very probably by the fact that this pronominal morph never has final stress anywhere.¹⁵ Apart from this, the marker could be regularly used, within the limits of acceptable stress patterning, only in 1cs and 2ms forms. Even here, the long penultimate vowel in forms from final weak roots blocked the development regularly in *qal* forms and often elsewhere. Finally, the development was blocked by the suprasegmental contours in the three cases noted above: pause, the conjoined pair, and before a word stressed on its first syllable. This explains why these *waw* consecutive perfect forms appear in the last situation, to show the only cases of retraction of the accent to a closed syllable. There is no retraction involved. The stress is merely maintained in its original position.¹⁶

9. *Nesiga* was a late development in the history of the biblical text. It occurred before the accentuation was fixed in its present form; but is much closer to the present accentuation than are the other features induced by the suprasegmental contours of an earlier stage of the Biblical reading tradition, such as pausal forms, or *qames* on conjunctive *waw*, which sometimes conflict sharply with the accentuation.¹⁷ The shift to final stress in *waw* consecutive perfect forms in contextual position must, then, also be late, since it was blocked by the phenomena which produced *nesiga*. As is shown in note 13, it is unlikely that *nesiga* arose before the turn of the era. Consequently the distinguishing mark of the semantic category “*waw* consecutive perfect” almost certainly arose after this form had ceased to be used even in contemporary literature, and probably arose within the biblical reading tradition.

über hebräische Morphologie und Vokalismus, p. 19, 22, 35, 43, 52, 64, 78. See also Blau, p. 99).

¹⁴ “Unmotivated” penultimate stress is shown in about 4% of the 73 forms from roots III *ʔ* in stems other than *qal*, and in about 21% of the 87 forms from roots III *h*. The only *qal* forms with final stress are *wəʔpīt'ə* (Lev 24:5) and *ubəʔt'ə* before *alef* with *pataḥ* or *segol* (Gen 6:18, etc., but not Dt 12:26).

¹⁵ The relative rarity of these forms may also have been a factor if, as is suggested below, the change took place late, and so within the reading tradition of the biblical text, not in general linguistic usage.

¹⁶ The situations called “minor pause” are, then, cases where the form stood at the end of a phrase, so that final stressing was not induced, but that phrase did not stand at the end of a unit of significance sufficient that the suprasegmental contours induced pausal vowel change.

¹⁷ For examples see JSS 25 (1980), 168; HAR 5 (1981), 82–4. The only sharp conflict in the case of *nesiga* is *mah-p'ə'al ʔel* (Nu 23:23), the only case of retraction of stress in a word with a disjunctive accent.

10. THE *waw* CONSECUTIVE IMPERFECT.

The stressing of *waw* consecutive imperfect forms differs from that of other uses of the imperfect only in 3ms, 3fs, 2ms, 1cs, and 1cpl forms (i.e. those which end, in MT, with the last root letter), and this difference is not always shown in 1st person forms. These forms are stressed as follows:

10.1 Forms ending in a consonant show penultimate stress in contextual position, where the penultimate syllable is open, as follows:-

(i) In forms from roots III *h*, in all positions, as *wayy'iben*.

(ii) In most other two-syllable forms in contextual position, as *wayy'ʔqom*, *wayy'ʔper*, *wayy'ešeb*, *wayy'ôreš*, *wayy'oʔkal*, but not with vowel pattern *i-a*, *u-a*, or *e-o*, as *wayyîʔab*, *wayyûšab*, *watteh'om*.

(iii) In some longer forms from the *nifʕal*, *piʕel*, or *hiʔaʕel* stems of other roots, in contextual position, as *wayyeʔʔsep*, *wayyill'ʔhem*, *wayyab'orek*, *wattip'ʔem*.¹⁸

10.2 Final stress occurs in all other forms ending in a consonant, including those described in #10.1.(ii) and (iii) in pausal position.

10.3 Forms ending in a vowel show penultimate stress in forms from *hyh* and *hyh* in pausal position, as *wayy'ehi*, and in forms from *rʔh* (other than 3ms) in all positions, as *watt'ereʔ*.

10.4 Final stress occurs in all other forms, that is, forms with final *alef*, as *wayyeš'eʔ*, *wayyab'iʔ*, and forms from *hyh* and *hyh* in contextual position, as *wayah'i*.

11. The *waw* consecutive imperfect forms ending in a vowel conform to the standard stress pattern described above (except for the forms from *rʔh*, for obvious historical reasons). Forms from the roots *hyh* and *hyh* follow the same pattern as other words arising from *CVCy with a short vowel, showing final stress in contextual position, and penultimate stress in pause. Forms with final *alef* show final stress in all positions, as do other members of group #2.2. It is, then, reasonable to assume that forms ending in a consonant would also originally have conformed to standard patterns by showing final stress. Among the forms ending in a consonant, the stressing of forms

from roots III *h* presents a standard exception to the standard pattern since they belong to the segolate category (#2.1.i). Apart from these, most contextual, and all pausal forms, show the expected final stressing. Those forms listed in #10.1.(ii) and (iii) which do show penultimate stress cannot be considered typical of *waw* consecutive imperfect forms, and are almost unique in Hebrew in failing to stress a final closed syllable the vowel of which is original (cf. #2.1). When they are placed in this context, it is difficult to believe that the penultimate stress which they show is a genuine survival from an earlier stage of the language.

12. The common assumption, maintained by Blau, that the penultimate stressing of these forms is a genuine survival, faces formidable obstacles. The most significant seem, indeed, insurmountable.

12.1 It is generally accepted that jussives and imperatives originally ended in a closed syllable wherever *waw* consecutives did. Jussives and imperatives, however, show final stress, with the exception of *hišš'omer*. Blau himself suggests that this exception may not be a residue of penultimate stress.¹⁹ That this is the correct view is suggested by the fact that, with *waw* consecutive perfect forms, a closed antepenult is conducive to final stressing (see #7), so that if stress had shifted from penult to final in imperatives, it would have been likely to do so in this form.

12.2 The *waw* consecutives, jussives, and imperatives which have final stress in context—including the forms with final *alef* listed in #10.4—also have final stress in pausal position. This contrasts with the forms listed in #2.3, 2.4.(i)–(iii), including 3fs perfect forms, which show final stress in context, but penultimate in pause. Presumably the final *-t* of the 3fs perfect was lost in word-final position before the standard stress pattern,

¹⁹ Blau, p. 100. The ms imperative *nifʕal* of *šmr* appears in Is 7:4 with *e* in the final syllable, and final stress. Elsewhere (in the Leningrad ms) the final syllable has *ε*, and stress position (where marked) is penultimate. In 12 cases, the following word is *lak'v*, as Gen 24:6. Final stress is retracted before this word in a total of 24 cases. In six more stress is retracted before some other word beginning with *šewa*, as *ʕamad zəb'ulo* Hab 3:11. These are usually called cases of *nesiga*, but do not come within the definition given in #3.4, and appear to occur under circumstances different from those typical for *nesiga*. In Ex 23:21, Dt 24:8, 2 Kgs 6:9, and Job 36:21, *hišš'omer* is used before a word which is not stressed on its first full vowel.

¹⁸ As far as I have noted, these roots are III *p*, or II guttural, III *m* or *r*, except for *wayyiss'ʕamed* Nu 25:3.

described above, became fixed, so that this form follows the same pattern as the 3mpl form: *qatalat—*qat'alā—qat'alo in pause, qat'al'o in context. Word final *alef*, however, did not lose its consonantal value until after the loss of final short vowels.²⁰ The standard stress pattern was established by this time, and consequently forms such as wayyes'e²¹ are stressed as if the final syllable was closed (as #2.2). There is no evidence for penultimate stress in any of these *waw* consecutive forms.

12.3 *Waw* consecutive imperfects (from roots other than III *h*) which have penultimate stress in context have final stress in pause. Hetzron argues that this reflects the fact that pausal patterns require stress on the vowel before the last consonant of any form. This is true on the historic level represented by the standard stress pattern, described above, but it is not true on the synchronic level.²¹ There is thus no evidence for Hetzron's assertion that pausal stressing "overrides" other patterns. Pausal stressing just exemplifies the standard stress pattern: at the stage prior to the loss of final short vowels, words ending in a vowel had penultimate stress, words ending in a consonant had final stress. There is thus no evidence that final stress in those *waw* consecutive forms which show it did result from a forward shift in stress position. It is a much more reasonable assumption that the standard pattern, with stress on a final closed syllable, was standard for these forms also, and that where this pattern is not shown, stress had been retracted.

13. This assumption presents no problem for the reconstruction of the development of *waw* consecutive imperfect forms, following the usual view that these forms were originally "short," in that they had no final short vowel, in contrast to the ordinary imperfect form, which was "long" in that it had one.

13.1 In the short form from roots III *h*, the final syllable was treated as open from an early date, so that the form received penultimate stress under the

standard pattern: *yabniy—*y'ibni. In the long imperfect form, the standard pattern resulted in penultimate stress before the loss of final short vowels, final stress after it: *yabn'iyu—*yibn'i(y).²² The stressed final vowel of this long form persisted, appearing in MT as *ε*, as in *yibn'e*. The unstressed final vowel of the short form eventually fell away, leaving a consonant cluster which was usually broken up, giving rise to forms like *y'iben*.²³

13.2 In forms from hollow roots, the root vowel was evidently long in an open syllable, short in a closed one, in Semitic languages generally. This was also true, in Hebrew, of the "i" following the second root consonant in *hif'il* forms. Consequently, in forms of this type, the short form imperfect had a short vowel because the final syllable was always closed (*yaš'ub, *yaq'il). The corresponding syllable in the long form was originally open, so that it had a long vowel, by which it was distinguished from the short form even after the loss of final short vowels (*yaš'ubu—yaš'ūb *yaq'ilu—yaq'il).²⁴

²² The view that the long imperfect form in Hebrew reflects a *yVqVtVl* present form (as Akkadian *ibanni*) is untenable. See T. L. Fenton "The Absence of a Verbal Formation *yaqattal from Ugaritic and North-West Semitic" in *JSS* 15 (1970), 31–41, and, on the Amarna evidence, A. F. Rainey "Morphology and the Prefix-Tenses of West Semitized El-Amarna Tablets," *Ugarit-Forschungen* 7 (1975), 395–426 (especially p. 423), also S. Izre'el "The Gezer Letters of the El-Amarna Archive—Linguistic Analysis," *Israel Oriental Studies* 8 (1978), 13–90.

²³ Presumably different vowel patterns were originally used in these verbs (as in Arabic and Akkadian) so that the final vowel (here given as *i*) would have varied in quality. The final vowel in the *y'ibni form may not, originally, have been short. This could have contributed to its common retention in imperative forms (but see note 24) and perhaps to its occasional retention in *waw* consecutives. There is, indeed, some evidence that this vowel was retained for some time after the loss of modal and case vowels (see #15.2) suggesting that it was not as short as they.

²⁴ The vowel of the ms imperative form from hollow roots (but not from *hif'il* stems) is also lengthened. This presumably derives from analogy with the imperfect (not from the existence of a final vowel on the ms imperative). A similar development possibly gave rise to the imperative forms with final *-e* from roots III *h* (but see note 23).

²⁰ Consequently the introduction of an anaptyctic vowel was necessary to break up the final consonant cluster in words such as *diš²—d'eše².

²¹ See R. Hetzron, "The evidence for Perfect *y'aqtul and Jussive *yaqt'ul in Proto-Semitic," *JSS* 14 (1969), 11–12. The accent *silluq* is marked on the penultimate syllable in a few cases (where stress on a final open syllable is expected) in the Leningrad ms as Ps 15:3, 48:7, 55:14, 62:4.

13.3 In all other cases, the loss of final short vowels obliterated the distinction between short and long imperfect forms.

14.1 In MT the *waw* consecutive is distinguished from other uses of the imperfect by the form of the prefixed conjunction,²⁵ which appears as a long syllable. The conjunction also appears as a long syllable before a word stressed on its first syllable in a variety of situations (see #3.3) including before a verb (but not a word from another class) followed by a modifier (or subject). This could have arisen naturally before 3ms *waw* consecutive imperfect forms from roots III *h*, which had initial stress. This form of the conjunction could then have been transferred to other forms as a distinguishing mark of the otherwise generally unmarked semantic category "*waw* consecutive imperfect." Since other forms did not have initial stress, the consonant following the conjunction had to be doubled to maintain the length of the syllable. The same process has taken place in *hamm'e* and similar compounds.

14.2 It appears that the penultimate stressing of the 3ms *waw* consecutive imperfect form from roots III *h* was also taken as characteristic of the category, and was transferred to most other two-syllable forms in which stress could be retracted under the patterns shown by *nesiga*. The retraction spread to a few longer forms—probably those in which retraction was easiest for phonological reasons.²⁶ It did not, however, spread to forms ending in vowels (in which there

was a strong tendency to final stress in contextual position, see #2.3, 2.4.i–iii), nor to pausal forms (in which the pattern of terminal stress was too firmly fixed) nor, for unknown reasons, to forms like *way-yi'ab*. It is possible that the retraction of stress to penultimate position in these forms preceded the change in the form of the conjunction, but, if this is so, the above description would only require minor adjustment.

15. There is no very clear evidence for the date at which the marks which distinguish *waw* consecutive imperfect forms were developed. It seems likely, however, that this did not occur for some time after the difference between most long and short imperfect forms had been obliterated by the loss of final short vowels.

15.1 Since stress is retracted in forms with open penultimate only where the final syllable is closed, (as in *wayy'ešeb* but not *wayyēs'e*²⁷), the retraction presumably did not occur until word final *alef* had lost its consonantal value (see #12.ii).

15.2 The common occurrence of *hireq* in the prefix of *waw* consecutive imperfect forms from roots III *h* (as *wayy'iben*) suggests that the syllable remained closed much longer in these forms than in corresponding noun forms, where *segol* or *sere* is used in the corresponding syllable (as *š'edeq*, *š'ebeq*). If so, the loss of the final vowel from **wayy'ibni* (see #13.1) did not bring about segolization until a late period. Since segolization did occur in *watt'ere*²⁷, final *alef* must have retained its consonantal value until a late period.²⁷

15.3 If the loss of distinction between the short and long imperfect forms had caused such confusion as to

²⁵ Suggestions that the prefix to *waw* consecutive imperfect verb forms is, or includes, some verbal or adverbial element, as Hetzron, *op. cit.*, p. 9, are to be rejected. (Other examples are found in V. Maag, "Morphologie des hebräischen Narrativs," *ZATW* 65 [1953], 86–88, G. M. Schramm, "A Reconstruction of the Biblical Hebrew *Waw* Consecutive," *General Linguistics* 3 [1957–8], 1–8, G. D. Young, "The Origin of the *Waw* Consecutive," *JNES* 12 [1953], 248–252). If the *waw* is the conjunction, the supposed additional element should be recognizable sometimes when the conjunction is not prefixed, and if the *waw* is not the conjunction, we need an explanation of why clauses with initial *waw* consecutives should be the only group not regularly introduced by a conjunction.

²⁶ *Nesiga* is rare in participles ending in a consonant which are not marked as construct but are followed by a noun. *Nesiga* occurs only where the final consonant of such a participle is labial, guttural (including *r*), voiceless, or *l*, and

occurs regularly only where the consonant is *p*, *m*, or *q*, as *t'orep t'orep* (Ez 22:25), *h'ôlem p'ô'am* (Is 41:7). The evidence is very limited, but it may suggest that retraction was more likely to take place from syllables ending in these consonants than from other closed syllables, in which case the longer forms of imperfect with *waw* consecutive which show penultimate stress may reflect the same phenomenon (see note 18).

²⁷ The transliterations of the second column of the Hexapla show that original short "i" in a doubly closed (or non-final closed) syllable was short even when stressed (as is generally true of short "a" in the Masoretic text) but do not provide information on change in quality.

require the development of a new mark of distinction as soon as final short vowels had been lost, the new mark should have been applied consistently. As it is, the original short form imperfect is distinguished (apart from *waw* consecutive forms) only where a distinction remained after the loss of the final short vowels (as described in #13), and only in the jussive use. In other cases where the short form was (presumably) once used, it has been replaced by the long form.²⁸ What was distinguished by the new marks was not the short form imperfect, but the *waw* consecutive use.

16. From the semantic point of view, it seems unlikely that the loss of distinction between the short and long imperfect forms should have caused confusion to any serious extent. Those familiar with the usage can easily recognize most *waw* consecutive imperfects whether they are formally distinct or no. The fact that a narrative refers to past time is usually clearly indicated by means other than *waw* consecutive verb forms. Such usage could have developed because these forms were not distinguished from ordinary imperfects, or it could, if existing already, have rendered such distinction unnecessary. In any case, there seems no reason to suppose that distinction was required until near the end of the biblical period, when the use of the *waw* consecutive imperfect

began to be abandoned. At the same time, the development of the participle into a real present tense was beginning, and the perfect and imperfect forms were beginning to take on the function of past and future tenses.²⁹ Thus not only was the literary use of the *waw* consecutive imperfect no longer familiar in everyday language; the value of the form was virtually the opposite of that of the corresponding form in the vernacular. Consequently some means of distinguishing the semantic category "*waw* consecutive imperfect" was required. It seems probable that the special form of the conjunction, and the retraction of stress of those *waw* consecutive imperfect forms which show it, came into use at this time.

17. It seems likely, then, that the stress patterns which distinguish some *waw* consecutive forms from the same forms in other uses were developed as a result of the change in the use of verb forms which began towards the end of the B.C. era, with imperfect forms distinguished first, perfect forms later. The question of date remains uncertain, however. What does appear certain is that the distinctive stress pattern is not, in either case, the vestige of a distinction much more general at an earlier stage of the language, but largely obliterated in MT. The stress patterns of MT clearly reflect a prior stage at which words ending in vowels had penultimate stress, while those ending in consonants had final stress. The pattern is much too regular, even in *waw* consecutive forms, to permit the argument that they did not conform to it.

²⁸ There may be isolated exceptions. E.g., the long form is used after ?z in forms from III *h* roots Jos 8:30, I Kgs 11:7, 2 Kgs 12:18, 15:16, 16:5, from hollow roots Ex 15:1, Nu 21:17, strong root *hif'il* Dt 4:41. The short form *hif'il yqhl* I Kgs 8:1 = *yqhyl* 2 Chron 5:2 may or may not be a genuine survival.

²⁹ See E. Y. Kutscher, *The Language and Linguistic Background of the Isaiah Scroll*, Leiden, 1974, 41–42, 351.